

Chapter 35-2: Illusion

Ning Fuyi exhaled and wiped her face with her sleeve, leaving only a faint sadness in her heart.

If it were the Ning Fuyi from her previous life, she would probably have been trapped in that memory. Unfortunately, she had already experienced too much pain - no matter how much she reminisced, she had become numb to it.

However... she raised her hand to look at her palm. The character that Ning Changfeng had written - those tactile sensations combined together seemed to form the character "love¹."

What was in the illusion was her memory. Later, when her memory became blurred, she had forgotten that Ning Changfeng had once written such a character for her.

Ning Changfeng had never told her she loved her while alive. Why did she write it when she was about to die?

Unable to understand, she stopped thinking about it and turned to look at Chu Qingqiu. Chu Qingqiu was also awakening at this moment. She gently opened her eyes, the grief in them disappearing in an instant.

It was as if the memories she had seen were nothing special at all.

That made sense - what sorrowful memories could Chu Qingqiu have? She probably didn't even understand what sorrow meant. Ning Fuyi turned her head to look at the void.

"What other tricks do you have?" Ning Fuyi said.

"What is precious? That which is treasured in the heart and one is unwilling to forget." The old man's voice rang out again. "Return."

As soon as his words fell, there was again an alternation of yin and yang. Ning Fuyi squinted to look, seeing only a blur before her, those scenes seeming to be covered by a thin veil, making everything unclear.

Just as she was about to rub her eyes, the wind by her ears suddenly stopped, and she was back in darkness.

What was happening? Had the Nightmare Beast run out of energy? Ning Fuyi was somewhat confused.

Obviously, it wasn't just Ning Fuyi who was confused - the Nightmare Beast, whose location was unknown, also seemed bewildered. The old man's heavier breathing could be heard, and then he said "return" again.

As if the scene was replaying, the wind sounded again, and the blurry scenes began rolling once more.

Then it stopped abruptly again. Ning Fuyi stood calmly in place with an unchanged expression, looking up at the void.

"Can you do this or not?" she frowned.

The Nightmare Beast became angry, so black and white began rapidly rolling before Ning Fuyi's eyes, making her dizzy. She simply closed her eyes and let the Nightmare Beast struggle.

After a long while, when it was quiet around her ears, she opened her eyes again. She was still standing in darkness, and the Nightmare Beast was obviously exhausted, just panting overhead, no longer trying to pull her into an illusion.

She had wanted to see what her precious memories were. Ning Fuyi was somewhat disappointed and turned to chat with Chu Qingqiu: "Divine Venerable..."

She stopped halfway through her words because she discovered that Chu Qingqiu was tightly closing her eyes, her body rigid in place, obviously still trapped in the illusion.

So it wasn't that the Nightmare Beast had run out of energy, but rather something about herself. Could it be that she had no precious memories? Ning Fuyi wondered. She walked in front of Chu Qingqiu and discovered that the corners of her mouth were actually slightly upturned.

Chu Qingqiu closed her eyes, her features so delicate they seemed carefully carved. Her dark brows were like willows, her eyelashes long, her lip color a bit pale but adding a touch of coldness.

Ning Fuyi's heartstrings trembled. Whether in her past life or this life, she had never seen Chu Qingqiu smile. What kind of memory could make her show such a smile?

Since she couldn't enter, she could only wait for Chu Qingqiu to wake up. At first, Ning Fuyi didn't think much of it, but as time slowly passed, she sensed something was wrong.

It had been too long. Chu Qingqiu had been trapped in memories for half the time it takes to burn a stick of incense, yet there was no change in her expression - if anything, the corners of her mouth were rising even more.

"Divine Venerable?" Ning Fuyi frowned. She tentatively waved her hand in front of her eyes but got no response.

Logically speaking, someone with Chu Qingqiu's cultivation level and mental fortitude shouldn't be ensnared by a mere illusion technique for so long.

"Chu Qingqiu." Ning Fuyi raised her voice, trying to wake Chu Qingqiu, but no matter how she called, the other person showed no reaction.

Although the white-bearded old man had said the Nightmare Beast wouldn't harm people, being trapped in an illusion for so long without coming out was still dangerous. Ning Fuyi's gaze sharpened as she prepared to forcibly wake her.

However, before she could touch Chu Qingqiu, a white light suddenly flashed around them, pulling her consciousness in.

Strange scenes appeared before her eyes.

In the scenes, there were only two people - one was a woman in white clothes, the other was a black shadow whose build and appearance couldn't be seen clearly, but seemed to be a woman, taller than the woman in white.

Most of the time they just sat together, each doing their own things without communication. However, after countless such scenes flashed by, their interaction seemed to change.

They began to sit closer and closer together. The woman seemed physically weak, and the black shadow would silently lift the woman horizontally, carrying her from inside the house to outside, with movements careful and gentle.

Later, such embraces became routine. When being held, the woman was always extremely quiet, and eventually she would even bow her noble head and curl up in the black shadow's arms.

Even later, they would occasionally kiss, but it was always the black shadow who initiated, and after the black shadow left, the woman would silently cry.

Finally, one day, they seemed to have an argument. The woman smashed everything around them, while the black shadow said nothing, suddenly picking her up and placing her on the bed. Their bodies suddenly drew close, and the woman's body went soft...

Ning Fuyi had seen such scenes before in her previous life, but she usually just watched coldly. Yet never had any scene made her face flush and her heart race like this moment.

Was Chu Qingqiu immersed in such memories? Ning Fuyi's gaze shifted slightly. So Chu Qingqiu wasn't truly without emotions - she had experienced them, and so deeply that they were unforgettable.

She just wondered who that person was, to be remembered so vividly by her, making her deeply trapped in illusions.

Ning Fuyi's mind wandered for a moment, but then she immediately came to her senses. She stepped into the scene, touched down lightly, leaped through the window, grabbed the black shadow and turned it around while simultaneously stabbing deeply into that person's chest with a dagger materialized from immortal power.

The black shadow let out a piercing scream, and at the same time, an intense tearing sensation struck. The scene before her eyes was instantly shattered.

Ning Fuyi seemed to wake from a great dream, gasping coldly. Opening her eyes to the familiar dark world, she realized she was somehow gripping Chu Qingqiu's hand. That hand was covered in sweat and suddenly withdrew from her palm.

Looking up, Chu Qingqiu had awakened. Her pale face finally had some color, her red lips almost pressed into a line, her eyes full of anger as she glared at Ning Fuyi.

Ning Fuyi hadn't expected to see such a scene and quickly stepped back: "I didn't mean to see it. Besides, if I hadn't pulled you out, who knows how long you would have been trapped inside."

"Don't worry, I didn't see anything clearly..."

"Shut up!" Chu Qingqiu said sternly.

Ning Fuyi understood her anger at having her past seen by someone. Rarely, she didn't argue with her but helplessly closed her mouth. At this moment, the old man in the void spoke again. But before he could utter the first word, White Bone from Chu Qingqiu's waist suddenly flew toward the void. There was a strange cry, and his voice stopped abruptly.

Ning Fuyi stepped aside, keeping her distance, feeling somewhat sorry for the exotic beast in her heart.

What were you thinking, provoking her when you already knew who she was?

At the same time, outside the illusion, everyone sat on the high platform, chatting idly while occasionally glancing at the arched door. Unfortunately, the arched door could only show the participants' images but couldn't let them hear their voices or know what kind of illusions they had entered.

But it wasn't without interest. After all, each person's performance after entering the illusion was vastly different - some laughed heartily, some cursed at the sky, others were deeply trapped in illusions, kneeling and wailing. For a moment, this single arched door showed all the various states of human life.

"Why is there no movement at all from Yiyi's side?" Liu Wenzhu shaded her eyes from the sun with her hand, looking worriedly at the arched door.

Just as she finished speaking, there seemed to be a tremendous sound from the horizon. The rainbow-shaped arched door shattered with a crash, and rolling black mist spread outward from the door as its center.

The disciples scattered in commotion, and the sect leaders and elders sitting in the front row quickly raised their hands to summon barriers, firmly protecting the high platform.

Twenty-eight disciples flew out with the black smoke, all falling to the ground. Some hadn't yet awakened from their illusions, with tears still on their faces. It wasn't until the wind dispersed the black smoke that they opened their confused eyes and looked in terror at Chu Qingqiu, whose figure was revealed from the black smoke.

Everyone who had seen Chu Qingqiu knew her to be cold and calm. They had never seen her with such an angry expression. Immediately, the entire venue fell silent, with no one speaking.

White Bone flew back from the void in a spinning motion, landing steadily in Chu Qingqiu's palm. Chu Qingqiu held a struggling little rabbit in her hand and threw it in front of the equally stunned white-bearded old man.

"Your exotic beast," she said, then strode through Zhaoyang Peak, over the high platform, and walked down the mountain.

Everyone looked at each other, not knowing what had happened. Finally, Elder Pingyao carefully spoke up: "Divine Venerable, this isn't finished yet. You..."

"I am feeling unwell and will take my leave first," she said coldly, walking straight through the crowd.

Footnotes:

1. **"Love" (爱)** - The Chinese character for love, which Ning Changfeng had written in Ning Fuyi's palm as she was dying